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NEW SKIES? Mayawati with 31-year-old nephew Akash Anand during a meeting in Delhi, July 8

BSP

GEN NEXT HAS A PLAN FOR BSP

By Prashant Srivastava

It's never easy to predict the political moves of Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) supremo Mayawati, who is known to hold her cards close to her chest. So much so that her decisions often take her party functionaries by surprise too. Now, when Opposition parties have come together to float the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance, or INDIA, and the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) is re-energising its National Democratic Alliance (NDA) ahead of the Lok Sabha election in 2024, Mayawati has chosen to maintain a cautious distance from the two blocs, while adding a new terminology to her strategic lexicon: 'balance of power'. Well, at least, till the outcome of the assembly polls in Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh and Telangana later this year.

So, on July 19, a day after the parallel Opposition and NDA meets, Mayawati told the media that the BSP will be entering the fray alone in the four states. But it took just about a week for her to soften her stance. After holding a meeting with senior party leaders in New Delhi, Mayawati on July 25 remarked that her party had emerged as a "balance of power in Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh by winning seats in consecutive assembly elections" before "power-hungry" parties used "various tricks to lure" the BSP MLAs. But, dropping hints about a possible post-poll alliance with either of the two blocs, Mayawati added that "the BSP can join the government" in these states to again "emerge as a balance of power" and "for the welfare of Dalits and backwards". (It was in Rajasthan that the BSP had won six seats in 2018 before its entire legislature group merged with the ruling Congress. In the other two states, it had won two seats each.)

MAYAWATI'S NEW STANCE REFLECTS HER NEPHEW AKASH'S PRAGMATIC OPENNESS ON JOINING WHICHEVER SIDE IS VICTORIOUS

A BSP veteran, who was part of the meeting, told INDIA TODAY that several Opposition parties want Mayawati to join the INDIA bloc, but 'Behenji', as she is popularly known, wants to first observe their performance in the four assembly polls, slated around November-December. "She will take the final decision after the results," he said, wishing not to be named. This gives party cadre a hope that they can at long last be a part of government regardless of who wins. It also keeps the BJP and Congress interested, so the backchannels with Mayawati will be buzzing.

Party insiders claim Mayawati's revised stance raises the profile of her 31-year-old nephew Akash Anand, who is at present the party's national coordinator and in-charge of the poll-bound states. It's he, say sources, who's keen on the party being a part of the ruling dispensations. Akash, who entered the political scene in 2017, first gained prominence during the Lok Sabha poll campaign in 2019. After the elections, Mayawati tasked him with organisational work in states other than the party's base, Uttar Pradesh. Now, when the BSP is going through a tough phase—it won just one of the 403 seats in the UP assembly in 2022—Akash is leading its revival plan and is often seen accompanying his aunt in party meetings.

"Behenji, too, understands the necessity of joining the government," says another senior leader. "She will take the final decision on the alliance by December-end." When the time comes, will the former UP chief minister spring another surprise, like she did while announcing a pre-poll alliance with her bête noire Samajwadi Party ahead of the Lok Sabha election in 2019? ■